

"WE GOT FULL COOPERATION FROM OPPOSITION-RULED STATES, EXCEPT IN CHHATTISGARH WHEN THE CONGRESS WAS IN POWER. THEY WEREN'T TOO ENTHUSIASTIC ABOUT HELPING OUR FORCES"

Q. With so many states involved, how did you ensure coordination between the Centre and these states, and did you face any difficulties?

The Modi government adopted a three-tier system of *samanvay* (coordination). There was coordination at the central and state ministerial levels, then at the state and district levels and the third aspect was coordination between the central agencies and state-level law and order agencies. Since I took charge in 2019, apart from ground visits to the Naxal-affected areas, I held 11 *samiksha* (review) meetings with the chief ministers of the LWE states, which included Union cabinet ministers, and 83 strategy meetings with the agencies. In these, we formulated strategies and provided swift solutions, including deploying central security forces and providing necessary resources like weapons. We got full cooperation from Opposition-ruled states, except in Chhattisgarh when the Congress was ruling, where we had a lot of problems.

Q. What were the issues in Chhattisgarh when the Congress was in power from 2018 to 2023?

I wouldn't say they were against the security forces but they were not very enthusiastic either. The full support that we needed from the state administration, including the *thalathis*, *thanas* (state police), forest and tribal departments, was not forthcoming. After the BJP came to power in Chhattisgarh, we have revived the campaign in the past 15 months. Starting January 2024, I had detailed review meetings with the new chief minister, the cabinet ministers concerned along with the top central government departments involved and formulated an action plan. We followed it up with detailed reviews in August and December 2024 and I personally visited many of the Naxalite areas. The results speak for themselves. In 2014, there were 18,000 sq. km of area in Chhattisgarh that was Naxal-affected. Today, that is down to 8,500 sq. km and decreasing rapidly every month. We organised a Bastar Olympics last year wherein those affected by Naxal violence participated. I also visited Naxalite-infested Sukma and Gundam areas to send a positive message to the people living there that the Modi government is their trusted compatriot in the battle for development.

"WE HAVE BROUGHT DOWN THE MOST NAXAL-AFFECTED DISTRICTS IN 10 STATES FROM 126 IN 2014 TO 12 NOW. THERE'S BEEN A MORE THAN 70% FALL IN SECURITY FORCES' AND CIVILIAN DEATHS"

Q. While the Maoist footprint may be shrinking for the moment, what are the chances of the movement's revival in these areas?

Revival of the movement is only possible if the government fails to provide schools, drinking water, roads and electricity in the villages. These are mostly tribal villages where residents get the benefits of reservation. They have priority in government recruitment and we have also relaxed the norms for physical fitness and education while recruiting them in the police. For instance, a special Bastariya Battalion of the CRPF was formed and we have recruited over 1,143 personnel from four highly Naxal-infected districts of Chhattisgarh. The recruitment process is on to fill around 6,500 posts in the police department in the state. The chances of revival are slim now. The Naxal ecosystem has been hit hard and is rapidly on its way out.

Q. What will be the yardstick to declare an area Naxal-free on March 31, 2026, and how confident are you of meeting the deadline?

If 98 per cent of the police stations in an area do not have a single incidence of Naxalism in the entire year, then the area will be declared Naxal-free. To the second part of your question, confidence by itself does not eliminate Naxals. *Kaafi kaam kar liya* (We have done enough work). I made the statement based on that. ■